
Paper 2 Blueprint

The Comprehension Toolkit for 1184

GCE O Level English Language 1184
Paper 2 (Comprehension)

Sections B & C
Every Question Type, Mapped

Version 10

Aligned to the 1184 Specimen Paper
Restructured by Section, then Category, then Question Type

Each question type appears in full detail wherever it occurs.

Question Type Atlas

The full map of every question type covered in this document

Section B — Narrative Comprehension (Text 3)

Category	Question Type	Marks
<i>Locate & Paraphrase</i>	LITERAL — factual recall from a named paragraph	1–2
	EVIDENCE — give detail, example, or evidence to support a claim	1–2
	QUOTATION — identify a specific word or phrase from the text	1
	OWN WORDS — paraphrase a phrase or idea in your own words	1–2
	EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE — support a claim with three pieces of evidence <i>plus</i> explanation	3
	CONTRAST — state the contrast between two things in the text	1–2
	FLOW CHART — choose phrases to summarise the role of each section	4
<i>Inference</i>	INFERENTIAL — explain what something suggests or implies	1–2
	CHARACTER IMPRESSION — describe the impression of a character	1–2
	TONE OF VOICE — identify the tone of a speaker's words	1
	LITERARY DEVICE — explain what a simile or metaphor suggests	1–2
	LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT — explain how language creates a specific effect	2–3
	TECHNICAL — identify what the writer <i>does</i> to create an effect	1–2

Section C — Non-Narrative Comprehension (Text 4)

Category	Question Type	Marks
<i>Locate & Paraphrase</i>	LITERAL — factual recall from a named paragraph	1–2
	QUOTATION — identify a specific word or phrase from the text	1
	OWN WORDS — paraphrase a phrase or idea in your own words	1–2
	GIVE EXAMPLE — find examples of a stated concept or value	1–2
	IDENTIFICATION — identify named items, features, or comparisons	1–2
	JUSTIFICATION — explain how the writer or actor could justify a claim	1–2
	WHY / GIVE REASON — explain the writer's reason for a choice	1
	EXPLANATION — explain in own words what a phrase or idea means	1–2
<i>Inference</i>	CARTOON HEAD — supply evidence to support a student's stated view	2–3
	ATTITUDE — identify the writer's attitude towards something	1
	INVERTED COMMAS — explain why the writer puts scare quotes on a word	1
	VOCABULARY — define a word and link it to the text	1–2
	TONE OF VOICE — identify the tone of the writer's comment	1

Question types that appear in both sections (LITERAL, QUOTATION, OWN WORDS, TONE OF VOICE) are presented in full in each section. The technique is the same; only the text type differs.

Chapter 1. How To Use This Document

What this document is

This document is a comprehensive question-type reference for the comprehension portion of GCE O Level English Language 1184 Paper 2. It covers Section B (narrative text) and Section C (non-narrative text) in full.

Visual text comprehension (Section A) and the summary question (Section C, Question 20) are not covered here. They are addressed in separate documents in the A-Worthy library.

How the document is organised

The document is structured in three levels:

1. **Section.** Section B (narrative) and Section C (non-narrative). These are the two main chapters.
2. **Category.** Within each section, question types are grouped into Locate & Paraphrase (where the answer is in the text and the work is to find it and reword it) and Inference (where the answer must be deduced).
3. **Question Type.** The individual question forms, each with its own concept, technique, worked example, and pitfalls.

The Core Move

A single underlying response shape runs through most inferential and explanatory question types in Paper 2. We call this the *Core Move*: **Anchor + Explain + Link**. You quote (Anchor), unpack (Explain), and tie back to the question (Link).

The Core Move is explained in detail in Chapter 2. Question types that use the Core Move are flagged with a CORE MOVE INSTANCE badge.

How to use this document for revision

- **Working through a past paper.** Identify each question's type using the Atlas page. Turn to that question type. Follow the technique.
- **Skill-building.** Pick a category (for example, Inference in Section B). Work through every question type in that category in order.
- **Cramming.** Read the focal *Sentence Structure to Memorise* box for each question type. Memorise the sentence pattern. The rest is application.

A note on syllabus alignment

The SEAB 1184 syllabus specifies three skill areas for Sections B and C: comprehension, vocabulary in context, and language for effect. The fourteen Section B question types and thirteen Section C question types in this document are practitioner taxonomies derived from past Cambridge papers and the official 1184 Specimen Paper. They map onto the syllabus skill areas but offer finer-grained guidance than the syllabus document itself.

Chapter 2. The Core Move — Anchor, Explain, Link

The single most important pattern in Paper 2

Most marks on Paper 2 are awarded for one underlying action: **quote the text, explain what the quotation means, and link the explanation back to the question**. This is the Core Move. Almost every inferential and explanatory question type — across both Section B and Section C — is a variation on this pattern.

► THE CORE MOVE

ANCHOR (a short quotation, in inverted commas) + **EXPLAIN** (what the quotation reveals, in your own words) + **LINK** (how the explanation answers the question asked).

Why this works

A marker's job is to confirm that you have done two things: (a) located the right evidence in the text, and (b) understood what that evidence means in context. The Anchor proves (a). The Explain proves (b). The Link makes the connection explicit so the marker does not have to do the work for you.

Many students lose marks not because their understanding is wrong but because they skip one of the three slots. They quote without explaining (Anchor only — marker sees evidence but no understanding). They explain without quoting (Explain only — marker cannot tell if you are reading the text or guessing). Or they quote and explain but never tie back to the actual question asked (Anchor + Explain only — marker has to infer that your answer is responsive).

The three slots in detail

Slot	What it does
Anchor	A short, accurate quotation from the named paragraph. Use inverted commas. Keep it short (one word to one short phrase). The quote must contain the meaningful word — not just framing words around it.
Explain	State in your own words what the quotation reveals. Do not repeat the quoted words back. Use synonyms. The explanation must add meaning that was not visible on the surface of the quotation.
Link	Tie your explanation back to the exact question. If the question asks what something <i>suggests about</i> X, your link should name X. If the question asks why the writer <i>chose</i> a phrase, your link should answer why.

Which question types use the Core Move

Twelve of the question types in this document are Core Move instances. They share the same underlying response shape; only the framing differs.

Question Type	Section	Core Move slot focus
INFERENCE	B	Anchor: the cue word/phrase. Explain: the implication. Link: what is suggested.
CHARACTER IMPRESSION	B	Anchor: the descriptive cue. Explain: the trait. Link: impression of character.
LITERARY DEVICE	B	Anchor: the simile/metaphor. Explain: comparison meaning. Link: what it suggests about X.
LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT	B	Anchor + Explain $\times$ 2 (or 3). Link: how the effect is created.
TECHNICAL	B	Anchor: the technique (named). Explain: how it works. Link: the effect achieved.
TONE OF VOICE (B)	B	Anchor: the speaker's words. Explain: the manner. Link: tone label.
JUSTIFICATION	C	Anchor: the relevant evidence. Explain: how it supports. Link: the claim.
WHY / GIVE REASON	C	Anchor: the cue. Explain: the reason. Link: why the writer chose this.
EXPLANATION	C	Anchor: the phrase. Explain: its meaning in own words. Link: what it conveys.
CARTOON HEAD	C	Anchor: evidence from named paragraph. Explain: how it supports. Link: the student's view.
ATTITUDE	C	Anchor: the cue word/phrase. Explain: its connotation. Link: the writer's stance.
INVERTED COMMAS	C	Anchor: the marked word. Explain: the implied opposite/irony. Link: writer's purpose.
VOCABULARY	C	Anchor: the word. Explain: its meaning. Link: why the writer chose it.
TONE OF VOICE (C)	C	Anchor: the writer's phrase. Explain: the manner. Link: tone label.

Question types that are NOT Core Move instances

Some question types do not use the Core Move because they do not require explanation. These are usually *Locate* questions where the marker only needs to see that you have found the right text:

- **LITERAL** — you find the answer and write it down. No explanation needed.
- **EVIDENCE** — you provide the detail or quotation. No explanation needed unless explicitly asked.
- **QUOTATION** — you reproduce a word or phrase from the text. No explanation needed.
- **OWN WORDS** — you paraphrase. The paraphrase itself is the answer; there is no Anchor + Explain + Link structure because the paraphrase replaces the original phrasing.
- **CONTRAST** — you state the two opposing things. No explanation needed (unless asked).
- **FLOW CHART** — you match phrases from a box. No explanation possible (one-word/short-phrase answers).
- **EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE** — this is technically three mini Core Moves bundled together; treated separately in Chapter 3.
- **GIVE EXAMPLE** — you provide examples; no explanation needed.
- **IDENTIFICATION** — you identify items; no explanation needed.

These question types have their own techniques, covered fully in Chapters 3 and 4.

Chapter 3. Section B — Narrative Comprehension

What Section B tests

Section B examines comprehension of a narrative prose extract, normally a passage from a novel or short story. The text is between roughly 600 and 800 words. It tells a story, usually from a first-person narrator's point of view, and features one or more characters with discernible motivations, reactions, and inner states.

Questions test three skills: (a) understanding of explicit content (**Locate & Paraphrase**), (b) inference about characters, feelings, and meaning (**Inference**), and (c) language analysis (a subset of Inference involving how the writer's word choices and techniques create meaning).

The section is worth 20 marks across approximately 9–10 questions. Mark allocations typically range from 1 to 4 marks per question.

Strategy for Section B

1. Read the text once through without answering questions. Get the gist.
2. Re-read paragraph by paragraph as you answer the questions.
3. Pay attention to mark allocation: it tells you how many points to give.
4. Pay attention to the number of lines provided in the question paper: it tells you roughly how much to write.
5. Quote accurately. Use inverted commas every time you lift words from the text.

Section B — Locate & Paraphrase Question Types

LITERAL — factual recall from a named paragraph

Concept. You are asked a question whose answer is stated directly in the text. Your job is to find the relevant words and write them down. Marker rewards: locating the right text and reproducing it accurately (or rewording it without changing meaning).

Why this exists. Cambridge needs to test that you can find and lift specific information accurately. These are the most accessible marks in Section B. They are almost always one or two marks each.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Action verb from the text], [object/detail from the text].

Example. Question: "What two things did Coach do to show his anger?"

Answer: "*Coach narrowed his eyes and clenched his jaw.*"

What the marker is looking for

- Direct location of the answer in the named paragraph.
- Accuracy: the answer must reflect what the text actually says.
- Number of points matches mark allocation: 2 marks usually means 2 distinct points.
- Be careful of the *Excess Denied rule*: if you list four things when only two are asked for, and one of them is wrong, you may lose the mark on the wrong one.

Step 1. Identify which paragraph the question names. Read only that paragraph.

Step 2. Underline the words in the paragraph that match what the question is asking.

Step 3. Count how many distinct points the question requires (look at mark allocation).

Step 4. Write the answer: lift the words, or paraphrase if you wish. Do not exceed the requested number of points.

Worked Example — LITERAL — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q6): When Coach was challenged, “Anger flashed in his icy blue eyes”. From Paragraph 1, give two other examples of physical evidence of his anger.

Model answer. “*His jaw tightened, and his fists clenched at his sides.*”

Why this works. The answer cites two distinct physical signs of anger, both lifted directly from the paragraph. It does not exceed the two-point requirement. Inverted commas are used because the answer is a direct lift.

A weaker attempt

“He was angry and looked scary.”

What went wrong. This answer repeats the question (he was angry) and offers an interpretation (looked scary) rather than the **physical evidence** the question asks for. The student has not located specific text and has invented a generic descriptor. Zero marks.

Pitfalls. Do not paraphrase if the question asks you to identify or give detail; lift exactly. Do not provide more points than the mark allocation requires (Excess Denied). Do not give vague answers like “he was angry”—this repeats the question.

EVIDENCE — provide detail, example, or evidence to support a claim

Concept. The question provides a claim (often a quotation) and asks you to give detail, evidence, or an example from the text that supports it. Different from LITERAL because the question is framed around *supporting an existing claim*, not retrieving raw facts.

Why this exists. This tests whether you can identify what *counts as* evidence for a particular point. The skill is matching: does this detail in the text actually back up the claim in the question?

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Quoted detail from the text in inverted commas], OR [paraphrased detail from the text].

Example. Question: “Give one detail showing how she felt nervous.”

Answer: “*Her hands were shaking.*”

What the marker is looking for

- Detail must come from the named paragraph (or named scope).
- Detail must actually support the claim. Off-target details earn nothing.
- Use inverted commas if you lift directly. If you paraphrase, do not change the meaning.
- For 2-mark questions, provide two clearly distinct details.

Step 1. Read the claim in the question. Identify the key idea (e.g. “physical evidence of anger”, “slow swimmer”).

Step 2. Read the named paragraph. Find details that match the key idea.

Step 3. Lift them with inverted commas, or paraphrase without changing meaning.

Step 4. Provide as many details as the marks demand.

Worked Example — EVIDENCE — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q9b): Give one piece of evidence from Paragraph 4 which suggests that the writer was a slow swimmer.

Model answer. “*Coach told her she was holding the team back.*”

Why this works. The detail is lifted from the named paragraph. It directly supports the claim (slow swimmer = holding team back is a recognised consequence). Inverted commas signal a direct lift.

A weaker attempt

“She swam slowly.”

What went wrong. This is not evidence; it merely restates the claim in the question. The student has not located specific words from the text. The marker cannot tell whether the student has read the paragraph.

Pitfalls. Do not state the claim back. Do not lift a detail from outside the named paragraph. Do not give a generic answer that any text could support.

QUOTATION — identify a specific word or phrase from the text

Concept. You are asked to identify (or quote) a specific word, phrase, or group of words from a named paragraph that does a specific job. The job might be: suggests X, conveys Y, emphasises Z, illustrates a contrast.

Why this exists. This tests close reading: can you spot the exact word or phrase that does the work? It is a more precise test than EVIDENCE because the answer is often a single word, not a full sentence.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

“[The exact word or phrase from the text, in inverted commas]”

Example. Question: “Identify one word in Paragraph 4 which suggests that Coach is surprised.”

Answer: “*Bewildered.*”

What the marker is looking for

- The quoted answer must be the exact text from the passage — no spelling changes.
- Inverted commas are mandatory.
- Match the word count: “one word” means one word. “A phrase” means more than one word but not a whole sentence. “Two words” means two separate words, identified separately.
- Only provide what is asked. Extra words can cost the mark.

Step 1. Read the question carefully. Note exactly what you must identify: a word? A phrase? How many?

Step 2. Identify the job the answer must do (e.g. “suggests surprise”).

Step 3. Scan the named paragraph for candidates.

Step 4. Test each candidate against the job. Pick the one that does it best.

Step 5. Write it in inverted commas. Spell it exactly.

Worked Example — QUOTATION — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q9a): Identify one word in Paragraph 4 which suggests that Coach is surprised that the writer wants to continue swimming.

Model answer. “*Bewildered.*”

Why this works. A single word, taken directly from the named paragraph. “Bewildered” carries the meaning of confused surprise. Inverted commas frame the quotation. No extra words.

A weaker attempt

“He was bewildered by her request.”

What went wrong. The question asked for *one word*. The student has given a full sentence. Even though the right word is in the answer, the student has not followed the instruction. The mark may be withheld.

Pitfalls. Watch the word-count instruction carefully. Do not paraphrase or explain — this question type asks for the word itself, not for what it means. Do not invent or alter spelling.

OWN WORDS — paraphrase a phrase or idea in your own words

Concept. The question explicitly directs you to answer “in your own words”. You must take an idea or phrase from the text and rephrase it using different vocabulary while preserving the meaning.

Why this exists. This is essentially a vocabulary test. The marker wants to see that you understand the meaning of the original well enough to express it in different language. Copying back from the text earns zero marks here, no matter how relevant the lifted material.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Subject from the text in your own words] [verb in your own words] [object in your own words].

Example. Original phrase: “the most important benefactors”

Own-words version: *The people who gave the most help and support.*

What the marker is looking for

- Different vocabulary from the text. Synonyms.
- Same meaning. No drift, no exaggeration, no understatement.
- Same intensity. “Hatred” becomes “animosity” or “loathing”—not “dislike” (too mild).
- Do not lift even short phrases. If the original says “calisthenics”, do not write “calisthenics” in your answer; write “warm-up exercises” or similar.

Step 1. Read the named phrase or sentence carefully. Understand what it says.

Step 2. Identify the key content words (nouns, verbs, adjectives). These are what you must change.

Step 3. For each key word, think of a synonym at the same intensity level.

Step 4. Write the sentence using your synonyms. Check that the meaning is unchanged.

Step 5. Re-read against the original. If any content word from the original appears in your answer, replace it.

Worked Example — OWN WORDS — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q8): Referring to Paragraph 3, explain in your own words what the writer thinks is unfair about the way Coach organises calisthenics.

Original text says. “Coach made the strongest swimmers do the easiest exercises, while the weakest swimmers had to do the most difficult ones.”

Model answer. *The most capable team members were given the gentlest warm-up routines, while those who struggled the most were assigned the toughest drills.*

Why this works. Every content word from the original is replaced: “strongest swimmers” becomes “most capable team members”; “easiest exercises” becomes “gentlest warm-up routines”; “weakest swimmers” becomes “those who struggled the most”; “most difficult ones” becomes “toughest drills”. The meaning is identical. The intensity is preserved.

A weaker attempt

“The strong swimmers did easy exercises and the weak swimmers did hard ones.”

What went wrong. Almost every content word is lifted directly from the text. “Strong”, “weak”, “swimmers”, “easy”, “hard”, “exercises” are all the original words (or their direct stems). The student has not paraphrased. Zero marks for an own-words question.

Pitfalls. Do not lift content words. Do not weaken the intensity (“hatred” to “dislike” is wrong). Do not over-elaborate; keep the rephrased version close to the original length. Do not change the sense.

EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE — support a claim with three pieces of evidence *plus* explanation

Concept. A claim is given (often a quotation from the text). You must find three pieces of evidence from the named paragraph that support the claim, and explain each one. This is a new question type introduced in the 1184 syllabus, worth 3 marks.

Why this exists. The 3-mark allocation signals that each evidence-plus-explanation pair earns one mark. The question tests whether you can both (a) find supporting evidence and (b) demonstrate understanding of how each piece supports the claim.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

Evidence 1: “[quote from text]” — this shows that [your explanation in own words].

Evidence 2: “[different quote]” — this shows that [different explanation].

Evidence 3: “[different quote]” — this shows that [different explanation].

What the marker is looking for

- Three distinct pieces of evidence. Not two close paraphrases of the same point.
- Each must be quoted (or paraphrased clearly) from the named paragraph.
- Each must be *explained*, not just listed. The explanation must use different words from the quotation.
- The explanation must show *how* the evidence supports the claim, not merely restate the claim.

Step 1. Identify the claim in the question. Note the named paragraph.

Step 2. Find three distinct details in the paragraph that support the claim.

Step 3. For each, write a short quotation in inverted commas.

Step 4. For each, write a one-sentence explanation in own words showing how it backs the claim.

Step 5. Check that no two pieces of evidence overlap. Each must add a new dimension.

Worked Example — EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q13): The writer claimed that she had had “the best workout ever”. Explain how this claim is supported with reference to three pieces of evidence from Paragraph 6.

Model answer.

Evidence 1: “*Her arms burned and her legs felt like jelly*” — this shows that her body was pushed to physical extremes, evidence of a maximal exertion.

Evidence 2: “*She had swum further than ever before*” — this shows that the session set a personal distance record, the hallmark of a peak workout.

Evidence 3: “*She felt the satisfaction of having mastered something fearful*” — this shows that the emotional reward of overcoming the storm reinforced the sense of having achieved something unprecedented.

Why this works. Three distinct pieces of evidence, each quoted accurately. Each explanation uses different words from the quotation and shows *how* the detail makes the claim of “best workout ever” justified.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

A weaker attempt

“She swam a long way and was tired. Her muscles hurt. She felt good.”

What went wrong. The student has listed three details but has not quoted any of them, has not explained them, and has not used inverted commas. The marker cannot tell whether the student is reading the text or summarising from memory. There is no demonstration of understanding beyond surface restatement. At most 1 mark.

Pitfalls. Do not give three pieces of evidence that all make the same point. Do not omit the explanations. Do not lift words from the quote into your explanation (use synonyms). Do not exceed three pieces; the marker only marks the first three.

CONTRAST — state the contrast between two things in the text

Concept. The question identifies two things in the text (two characters, two places, two atmospheres, two times) and asks you to state what the contrast between them is. You must name both sides of the contrast clearly.

Why this exists. This tests whether you can identify opposing qualities in the text. It is not a technical question — you are not asked *how* the writer creates the contrast, only *what* the contrast is.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[First side of the contrast: subject + descriptor], whereas [second side of the contrast: subject + descriptor].

Example. “The library was calm and silent, whereas the street outside was loud and chaotic.”

What the marker is looking for

- Both sides of the contrast must be named.
- The descriptors must be genuinely opposite, not just different.
- Use a connector like “whereas”, “while”, “but”, or “on the other hand” to signal the contrast.
- Do not explain *how* the contrast is created (that is a TECHNICAL question, not a CONTRAST question).

Step 1. Identify the two things being contrasted in the question. Note the paragraph reference.

Step 2. Read the paragraph. Find descriptive words for each thing.

Step 3. Pair up the opposing qualities (e.g. loud/quiet, busy/empty, warm/cold).

Step 4. Write a single sentence that names both sides and links them with a contrast connector.

Worked Example — CONTRAST — Section B

Question: What is the contrast between the atmosphere inside the library and outside in the street?

Model answer. “*Inside the library, the atmosphere was hushed, calm, and ordered, whereas outside in the street, it was noisy, chaotic, and crowded.*”

Why this works. Both sides of the contrast are explicitly named. The descriptors on each side (hushed/noisy, calm/chaotic, ordered/crowded) are genuinely opposite. The word “whereas” signals the contrast.

A weaker attempt

“The library was very quiet.”

What went wrong. The student has only described one side of the contrast. The marker cannot give credit for a contrast question if only one half is given. Both sides must be present.

Pitfalls. Do not give only one side. Do not explain how the writer creates the contrast (different question type). Do not pick descriptors that are similar rather than opposite.

FLOW CHART — choose phrases to summarise the role of each section

Concept. The question provides a flow chart with several stages (usually 4) and a box of phrases. You must choose the one phrase from the box that best summarises what happens or what the focus is at each stage. There are always extra phrases that act as distractors.

Why this exists. This tests your understanding of *paragraph-level meaning*: can you summarise the gist of a paragraph (or pair of paragraphs) using a short phrase? It is in essence a vocabulary-plus-comprehension test. You must understand both the paragraph and the subtle differences between the phrases in the box.

This question is worth 4 marks (1 per correct stage). It is confirmed in the 1184 Specimen Paper (Q14).

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

For each stage, write the chosen phrase exactly as it appears in the box. Do not paraphrase or shorten.

Example. “Paragraphs 1–2: questioning authority.”

What the marker is looking for

- One phrase per stage. The phrase must come from the box.
- Copy the phrase exactly. Do not paraphrase.
- The phrase must accurately describe the writer’s role (or whatever the question specifies) at that stage — not at a different stage.
- Distractor phrases will be close in meaning to the right answer. Read each candidate against the named paragraphs carefully.

Step 1. Read the question stem carefully. Identify what is being summarised (the writer’s role? the character’s feelings? the focus of the section?).

Step 2. Read all the phrases in the box. Note which ones are close in meaning (these are the distractor pairs).

Step 3. For each stage, re-read the named paragraphs. Identify the main action or feeling.

Step 4. Match the paragraph to the phrase that best captures it. Eliminate near-misses.

Step 5. Check: does each chosen phrase fit only *that* stage, or could it apply to another? If it could apply to another, re-test.

Worked Example — FLOW CHART — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q14): The structure of the text reflects the writer’s role in events at different stages during the training session. Complete the flow chart.

Box contains: *embracing a physical challenge; questioning authority; being an observer of events; considering an independent course of action; gaining a vision of new possibilities; negotiating a satisfactory compromise; offering words of encouragement.*

Model answer.

- Paragraphs 1–2: *being an observer of events* (the writer watches Coach and the younger swimmers; she is not yet active).
- Paragraphs 3–4: *questioning authority* (the writer challenges Coach’s organisation of calisthenics).
- Paragraph 5: *embracing a physical challenge* (she swims through the storm).
- Paragraph 6: *gaining a vision of new possibilities* (she realises she has had the best workout ever and sees herself as capable).

Why this works. Each phrase is lifted exactly from the box. Each maps clearly onto the gist of the named paragraphs. Distractors like “offering words of encouragement” (no one is encouraged) and “negotiating a satisfactory compromise” (no compromise occurs) are correctly rejected.

A weaker attempt

For Paragraph 5, student writes: “swimming through a storm”.

What went wrong. The student has paraphrased rather than copied a phrase from the box. The marker will not award the mark even if the meaning is correct, because the question explicitly directs the student to choose from the box.

Pitfalls. Do not paraphrase the chosen phrase. Do not use the same phrase twice (each is used at most once unless the question specifies otherwise). Do not be fooled by distractors; test each candidate against the named paragraph.

Section B — Inference Question Types

INFERENCEAL — explain what something suggests or implies

Concept. The question takes a detail in the text (a description, a piece of dialogue, an action) and asks what it suggests, implies, or indicates. The answer is not stated directly in the text. You must deduce it.

Why this exists. This tests whether you can read between the lines: see the meaning that an author has placed below the surface of the words.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The phrase “[*anchor: the cued words from the text*]” suggests that [*explain: the underlying meaning in your own words*], which [*link: ties back to the question — what is being shown about the person, situation, or moment*].

What the marker is looking for

- Anchor: short quotation from the text, in inverted commas.
- Explain: the meaning beneath the surface, in different words from the quotation.
- Link: explicitly answer what the question asks (“what does this suggest about X”).
- The inferred meaning must be defensible from the text. Wild guesses fail.

Step 1. Identify the words or detail the question is pointing to.

Step 2. Ask: what is the surface meaning? Then ask: what lies underneath?

Step 3. Identify the question’s target (e.g. “about the teammates” or “about Clara’s mood”).

Step 4. Build the answer: Anchor + Explain + Link.

Step 5. Check that your inference is plausible given the rest of the passage.

Worked Example — INFERENCE — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q7): In Paragraph 2, the writer’s “teammates leaped out of the pool, scurried across the deck, grabbed towels”. What does this description suggest about how the teammates felt in this moment?

Model answer. The verbs “*leaped*”, “*scurried*”, and “*grabbed*” suggest urgent, almost panicked movement, which implies that the teammates felt cold, miserable, and desperate to get out of the water as quickly as possible.

Why this works. The anchor cites three specific cue words. The explain unpacks what they reveal (urgent, panicked movement). The link answers the question (cold, miserable, desperate to escape the water).

A weaker attempt

“They felt cold.”

What went wrong. The student has guessed the right feeling but provided no evidence and no explanation. There is no anchor (no quoted cue), no explain (no unpacking of the verbs), and no demonstration of inference. The marker may award 0 or partial credit depending on how generous they are; the answer is bare.

Pitfalls. Do not state only the inference. Do not lift words without explaining them. Do not invent inferences that the text does not support. Watch for question signals: “suggest”, “imply”, “what do you think” all mean “inference required”.

CHARACTER IMPRESSION — describe the impression of a character

Concept. The question asks what impression you get of a character from a paragraph, or what sort of person a character is based on their behaviour or words. The answer is a character trait (single word or short phrase) backed by evidence and explanation.

Why this exists. This tests inference about people: can you read a character's traits from their actions, words, and described appearance?

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Character name] comes across as [trait word(s)]. This is shown by “[*anchor*]”, which reveals [explain in own words], demonstrating [link to the trait].

Alternative one-word/short-phrase version (for low-mark questions): [Trait word(s) only.]

What the marker is looking for

- Build a vocabulary bank for character traits. Single words like *ambitious*, *controlling*, *compassionate*, *vindictive*, *perceptive*, *evasive*, *ruthless*, *magnanimous*.
- For 1-mark questions: trait word(s) alone may suffice.
- For 2-mark questions: trait + evidence + explanation.
- The trait must be supportable from the named paragraph. Generic positive/negative descriptors are weak.

Step 1. Read the named paragraph. Note what the character says, does, or how they are described.

Step 2. Identify the dominant impression. Find a precise trait word.

Step 3. Pick the strongest piece of evidence for the trait.

Step 4. Write the trait, the evidence in inverted commas, and the explanation.

Worked Example — CHARACTER IMPRESSION — Section B

Question: What impression do you get of Alma from Paragraph 5?

Model answer. Alma comes across as *determined and uncompromising*. This is shown by her “*emphatic tone*” that “*brooked no argument*”, which reveals that she has made up her mind and is unwilling to be persuaded otherwise, demonstrating a firm, resolute character.

Why this works. The trait is precise (“determined and uncompromising” rather than “strong”). The evidence is quoted accurately. The explanation makes the link between the cue (no argument allowed) and the trait (uncompromising).

A weaker attempt

“She is a strong person.”

What went wrong. The trait is vague (“strong” could mean physically strong, emotionally strong, or strong-willed). There is no evidence. The marker cannot verify that the student has read the paragraph. At most 0–1 marks.

Pitfalls. Do not use vague descriptors like “nice”, “bad”, “strong”. Do not give a trait that contradicts the rest of the passage. For multi-mark questions, do not omit evidence.

TONE OF VOICE — identify the tone of a speaker's words

Concept. The question asks for the tone of a character's spoken words (or, in some Section C questions, the writer's tone). The answer is a tone word: one word or short phrase that describes the manner of speech.

Why this exists. Tone is a precise reading skill: the same words can be said in different tones and mean different things. The question tests whether you can pick up tonal cues from context.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Tone word or short phrase].

Or, for 2-mark questions: The tone is [tone word]. This is shown by “[anchor]”, which suggests that the speaker [explain].

What the marker is looking for

- Build a vocabulary bank for tone words. Examples: *sarcastic, accusatory, weary, exasperated, defiant, conspiratorial, conciliatory, dismissive, urgent, sombre, indignant, wry, plaintive, scornful*.
- Tone is different from feeling. Feelings describe what the speaker *is*; tone describes how the speaker *sounds*.
- For 1-mark questions: tone word alone is the answer.
- Cues for tone: punctuation (exclamations, ellipsis), word choice, sentence length, what the speaker is reacting to.

Step 1. Read the quoted speech and its immediate context.

Step 2. Identify cues: punctuation, word choice, what triggered the speech, the speaker's known mood.

Step 3. Choose a tone word that captures all the cues.

Step 4. For higher-mark variants, add evidence and explanation.

Worked Example — TONE OF VOICE — Section B

Question (2019): What is the tone of the brother's comment about his sisters?

Brother's comment in the text: “*They were like greedy birds.*”

Model answer. *Disdainful* (or *scornful*).

Why this works. The comparison to “greedy birds” is unflattering and reductive. The brother is not just describing his sisters; he is looking down on them. “Disdainful” captures this. The tone word is precise.

A weaker attempt

“Angry.”

What went wrong. “Angry” is the feeling, not the tone. The brother is not raging; he is sneering. “Angry” is too crude a label for the cool contempt the comparison reveals.

Pitfalls. Do not confuse tone with feeling. Do not give a generic word like “sad” or “happy” when a more precise tone word is available. Build the vocabulary bank early.

LITERARY DEVICE — explain what a simile or metaphor suggests

Concept. The question identifies a simile, metaphor, or other literary device in the text and asks what it suggests about a specific thing (the writer’s ability, the character’s feelings, the situation). You must recognise the device and explain what the comparison reveals.

Why this exists. Cambridge confirms that candidates will not be asked to *define* literary devices, but will be required to *recognise* them and evaluate their effect. Section B regularly tests this with similes.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The simile/metaphor “[*anchor*]” compares [thing X] to [thing Y]. This suggests that [explain: the meaning of the comparison], which links to [link: what the question asks about].

What the marker is looking for

- Identify the device correctly (simile uses “like” or “as”; metaphor states one thing is another).
- Name the two things being compared.
- Explain what the comparison reveals (not what the device technically is).
- Tie back to the specific aspect the question targets (e.g. “ability to move”, “view of his sisters”).

Step 1. Identify the device. Confirm it is a simile/metaphor as described.

Step 2. Identify thing X and thing Y in the comparison.

Step 3. Ask: what qualities of Y are being projected onto X?

Step 4. Connect those qualities to what the question targets.

Step 5. Write the response: Anchor + Explain + Link.

Worked Example — LITERARY DEVICE — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q12): In Paragraph 5, the writer uses the simile “the pool was like a giant bowl of icy porridge”. What does the simile suggest about the writer’s ability to move?

Model answer. The simile “*a giant bowl of icy porridge*” compares the water to a thick, semi-solid substance. This suggests that the writer’s movements were slowed and weighed down by the cold, dense water, implying that she could barely swim against its resistance.

Why this works. The simile is correctly identified. The two things compared (pool, porridge) are named. The qualities transferred (thick, semi-solid, viscous) are explained. The link to the question (ability to move = slowed, weighed down, can barely swim) is explicit.

A weaker attempt

“It was cold.”

What went wrong. The student names a quality of porridge (cold), but the question is about *ability to move*, not about temperature. The viscosity dimension of the simile is missed entirely. Off-target.

Pitfalls. Do not just say “it is a simile” — the question asks what the simile suggests, not what type of device it is. Do not focus on the wrong quality of the compared object. Always tie back to the question’s target.

LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT — explain how language creates a specific effect

Concept. The question states an effect the writer creates (e.g. “makes the storm seem like an aggressive person”, “emphasises the leanness of the wolves”) and asks you to explain how the language in the named paragraph achieves it. You must give two or three pieces of evidence and explain how each contributes to the stated effect.

Why this exists. This is the syllabus’s “language for effect” skill in pure form. The marker wants to see that you can read the writer’s choices closely and connect them to a specific effect.

This question may carry 2 or 3 marks in 1184 (it was usually 3 in past papers).

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The writer uses [device or phrasing] “[*anchor 1*]” which suggests [explain 1], creating the effect of [link to stated effect]. Similarly, “[*anchor 2*]” [explain 2], reinforcing this by [link 2].

For 3 details, repeat with a third anchor+explain+link.

What the marker is looking for

- Match the number of details to the marks: 2 marks usually means 2 details; 3 marks usually means 3 details.
- Each detail must be quoted briefly. Use inverted commas.
- Each must be *explained* — repeat the explained idea, not the quoted words.
- Each must link to the specific effect stated in the question (not a generic “creates an effect”).
- Use “suggests” as the analytic verb. Avoid simply restating the effect.

Step 1. Identify the specific effect named in the question (e.g. “makes the storm seem like an aggressive person”).

Step 2. Scan the named paragraph for words and phrases that contribute to that effect.

Step 3. Pick the strongest two or three (matching mark allocation).

Step 4. For each, write a short quotation, an explanation in different words, and a link to the named effect.

Step 5. Avoid repeating the same explanation across different quotations.

Worked Example — LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT — Section B

Question (1184 Specimen Q10): In Paragraph 5, the writer is swimming during a storm. Explain how the language used in this paragraph makes the storm seem like an aggressive person. Support your answer with two details from Paragraph 5.

Model answer. The writer describes the storm as having “*angry fists of wind*” that “*punched the water*”, which gives the storm human-like aggression — as if it is physically attacking the pool with a person’s hostility. Similarly, “*the rain spat at her face*” suggests deliberate, contemptuous action, as though the storm is targeting her personally rather than acting indifferently as weather normally does.

Why this works. Two distinct details are quoted. Each is explained: the first connects fists and punching to physical assault; the second connects spitting to deliberate contempt. Both link back to the question’s specific effect (storm seeming like an aggressive person).

A weaker attempt

“The writer uses personification. The storm is described as if it is a person.”

What went wrong. The student has named the device (personification) but has not quoted any specific words and has not explained how the personification creates the named effect. The answer is too general; any storm passage could provoke this response. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not just name the device. Do not give two details that make the same point. Do not lift the words from your quote into your explanation (use synonyms). Match the count to the marks.

TECHNICAL — identify what the writer *does* to create an effect

Concept. The question asks what the writer *does* (the technique, the method) to emphasise something, create a contrast, suggest a quality, and so on. Unlike LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT, you are not asked to quote evidence and analyse it; you are asked to name the technique itself.

Why this exists. This tests whether you can recognise writerly devices and conventions: short sentence vs long sentence, repetition, rhetorical question, contrast, ellipsis, hyperbole, listing, alliteration, irony.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The writer uses [technique: short sentence / repetition / contrast / rhetorical question / etc.], which [explain what the technique does], [link to the stated effect].

For 2-mark questions: Provide two techniques, each with its own brief explanation.

What the marker is looking for

- Name the technique correctly. Use precise terminology: *short sentence, repetition, rhetorical question, listing, hyperbole, ellipsis, dramatic contrast, direct address, alliteration, irony, pun, personification*.
- Briefly explain how the technique creates the effect.
- Avoid the trap of quoting and analysing words — that is LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT. This question is about the *technique*, not the specific words.

Step 1. Identify the effect named in the question (e.g. “emphasises Lucy’s surprise”).

Step 2. Scan the named paragraph for technique cues: very short sentences? Repetition? A rhetorical question? An exclamation? A pause (ellipsis)? A contrast?

Step 3. Name the technique using precise terminology.

Step 4. Briefly explain how this technique creates the stated effect.

Worked Example — TECHNICAL — Section B

Question (2022): Give two ways in which the writer emphasises Lucy’s surprise.

Model answer.

Way 1: The writer uses a *short, exclamatory sentence* (“*She froze.*”) which abruptly halts the narrative pace, mirroring Lucy’s mental shock and forcing the reader to register her surprise.

Way 2: The writer uses *ellipsis* (“*the house . . . was empty*”) which creates a pause that captures the moment of Lucy’s realisation, suggesting that she could not at first take in what she was seeing.

Why this works. Two distinct techniques are named with precise terminology (short sentence + ellipsis). Each is briefly illustrated and explained. Both link to the stated effect (emphasising surprise).

A weaker attempt

“The writer uses big words.”

What went wrong. “Big words” is not a recognised technique. The student has not identified the writer’s actual craft choices. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not confuse with LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT (where you analyse specific words). Do not name vague things like “descriptive language” or “adjectives”. Use the recognised vocabulary of writerly technique.

Chapter 4. Section C — Non-Narrative Comprehension

What Section C tests

Section C examines comprehension of a non-narrative prose text: typically a journalistic article, an opinion piece, or an informational article. The text is usually a few hundred words longer than the Section B narrative. It presents arguments, evidence, comparisons, and claims rather than telling a story.

The section is worth 25 marks across approximately 5–7 comprehension questions plus the summary question. This document covers the comprehension questions only; the summary question is treated in a separate A-Worthy document.

The same three skill areas apply as in Section B: comprehension, vocabulary in context, and language for effect. However, the texture of the writing is different, so several question types appear in Section C that are uncommon or absent in Section B.

Strategy for Section C

1. Read the text once through without answering questions. Identify the writer's overall stance.
2. Re-read paragraph by paragraph as you answer the questions.
3. Note the mark allocation and number of lines provided.
4. Answer the summary question last.
5. Quote accurately, with inverted commas. Distinguish between literal answers (where you can lift) and explanation answers (where you must use own words).

A note on overlap with Section B

Four question types from Section B reappear in Section C: **LITERAL**, **QUOTATION**, **OWN WORDS**, and **TONE OF VOICE**. The technique is identical in both sections; only the text type differs. Each is reproduced in full here so the chapter is self-contained, with a cross-reference note flagging the duplication.

Section C — Locate & Paraphrase Question Types

LITERAL — factual recall from a named paragraph

Note. This question type also appears in Section B (see Chapter 3). The technique is identical: locate the relevant text in the named paragraph and report it. The only difference is that Section C texts present arguments or information rather than narrative, so the “facts” to be located are claims, statistics, descriptions of objects, or features — not character actions or feelings.

Concept. You are asked for a fact, feature, reason, or detail that is stated directly in the text. Lift it or paraphrase it. The answer is in the named paragraph.

Why this exists. These are the easiest marks in Section C. Cambridge uses them to confirm you can read and locate specific information in a non-narrative context.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Subject from the text] [verb or descriptor from the text].

For 2-mark questions: The two [features/reasons/factors] are: [point 1], and [point 2].

What the marker is looking for

- Answer is in the named paragraph.
- Match the number of points to the mark allocation.
- Be careful of the *Excess Denied* rule: if asked for two, give two, not three.
- Lifting is acceptable; paraphrasing is acceptable. Use inverted commas if lifting.

Step 1. Identify the named paragraph and the specific information requested.

Step 2. Locate the relevant sentences. Underline them.

Step 3. Count the points: how many does the mark allocation expect?

Step 4. Write the answer, lifting or paraphrasing. Do not exceed the requested count.

Worked Example — LITERAL — Section C

Question (1184 Specimen Q16a): From Paragraph 2, give two features of the real Dilophosaurus which were incorrect in the films.

Model answer.

Feature 1: “*The real Dilophosaurus did not have a frill around its neck.*”

Feature 2: “*It was much larger than the films showed.*”

Why this works. Two distinct features are lifted from the named paragraph. Both are accurate to the text. The count matches the mark allocation. Inverted commas mark the lifts.

A weaker attempt

“The films got the size wrong.”

What went wrong. Only one feature is given when two are asked for. The student forfeits half the marks.

Pitfalls. Do not give one when two are asked for. Do not stray outside the named paragraph. Do not paraphrase incorrectly.

QUOTATION — identify a specific word or phrase from the text

Note. This question type appears in Section B in identical form. In Section C, the text is non-narrative, so the words you are asked to identify usually do an argumentative or descriptive job (rather than a character-revealing job).

Concept. The question asks you to identify a specific word, phrase, or group of words from a named paragraph that does a specific job (suggests, conveys, illustrates, contrasts).

Why this exists. Tests close reading and precise location.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

“[The exact word or phrase from the text, in inverted commas]”

What the marker is looking for

- Quote exactly. Spelling matters.
- Use inverted commas.
- Respect the word count instruction (one word, a phrase, two separate words, not more than X words).
- Provide only what is asked. Excess text can void the mark.

Step 1. Note exactly what to identify: a word? A phrase? How many?

Step 2. Identify the job the answer must do.

Step 3. Scan the named paragraph for candidates that do that job.

Step 4. Pick the best candidate. Write it in inverted commas, spelt exactly.

Worked Example — QUOTATION — Section C

Question (2015): In Paragraph 2, which group of words tells us that it is not essential for the fields to be underwater to grow rice?

Model answer. *“Rice can also be grown on dry land.”*

Why this works. A precise group of words is quoted. The chosen text directly conveys the idea that flooding is not essential. Inverted commas frame the quotation.

A weaker attempt

“Rice doesn’t always need water.”

What went wrong. The student has paraphrased rather than quoted. The question asks which *group of words* from the text tells us this — it does not ask you to put it in your own words. No mark.

Pitfalls. Do not paraphrase. Do not exceed the requested word count. Do not give a whole sentence when a phrase is asked for.

OWN WORDS — paraphrase a phrase or idea in your own words

Note. This question type appears in Section B. The technique is identical. In Section C, the phrases to paraphrase are usually more abstract or formal (since the text is non-narrative), so vocabulary range matters even more.

Concept. The question directs you to answer in your own words. You must rephrase the relevant idea using different vocabulary while preserving the meaning.

Why this exists. This is a vocabulary test in disguise. The marker checks that you understand the meaning of the original well enough to express it differently.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Subject in your own words] [verb in your own words] [object/predicate in your own words].

What the marker is looking for

- Different vocabulary from the text.
- Same meaning, same intensity.
- Do not lift content words.
- Length should be roughly the same as the original.

Step 1. Read the named phrase carefully.

Step 2. Identify each content word (noun, verb, adjective).

Step 3. For each, find a synonym at the same intensity level.

Step 4. Write the sentence with all key words replaced.

Step 5. Check the meaning is unchanged.

Worked Example — OWN WORDS — Section C

Question (2017): Explain in your own words why the main streets within towns were often paved with stone.

Original text says. “*The main thoroughfares were paved with stone to prevent the surface from being damaged by heavy traffic.*”

Model answer. *The principal roads were surfaced with rock to protect them from wear caused by frequent vehicle use.*

Why this works. “Main thoroughfares” becomes “principal roads”; “paved” becomes “surfaced”; “stone” becomes “rock”; “prevent...damaged” becomes “protect...wear”; “heavy traffic” becomes “frequent vehicle use”. Every content word is replaced. Meaning preserved.

A weaker attempt

“The streets were paved with stone so heavy traffic would not damage them.”

What went wrong. Almost every key word (“streets”, “paved”, “stone”, “heavy traffic”, “damage”) is lifted directly. This is not a paraphrase.

Pitfalls. Do not lift content words. Do not weaken intensity. Do not over-elaborate.

GIVE EXAMPLE — find examples of a stated concept or value

Concept. The question quotes a general concept from the text (e.g. “values of the players”, “benefits of membership”) and asks you to provide specific examples of it from a named paragraph. You are looking for items that fit a stated category.

Why this exists. This tests whether you can recognise category-membership: which specific things in the text are instances of the concept named in the question? Similar to LITERAL but more focused on categorisation.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Example 1], [Example 2], and [Example 3].

Or: The three examples are: [example 1]; [example 2]; [example 3].

What the marker is looking for

- Examples must come from the named paragraph (or named scope).
- Each example must clearly fit the concept named in the question.
- Match the number of examples to the mark allocation.
- Lifting is permitted; paraphrasing is permitted.
- Be careful of the *Excess Denied* rule.

Step 1. Identify the concept named in the question.

Step 2. Read the named paragraph. Find items that are instances of the concept.

Step 3. Pick the strongest, most clearly fitting examples (matching mark count).

Step 4. List them clearly, separated by punctuation.

Worked Example — GIVE EXAMPLE — Section C

Question (2014): The writer summarises the traditional benefit of sport as “the extent to which it develops the understanding and values of the players”. Which three examples of such values are given in Paragraph 1?

Model answer. The three examples are: *teamwork, fair play, and perseverance.*

Why this works. Three distinct values are lifted from the named paragraph. Each is clearly a “value” (the concept named in the question). The list format is clear.

A weaker attempt

“Sport teaches you good things.”

What went wrong. No specific examples given. The student has restated the question’s claim in general terms. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not list things that are not examples of the named concept. Do not give general statements. Do not exceed the requested count.

IDENTIFICATION — identify named items, features, or comparisons

Concept. The question asks you to identify specific items mentioned in the text: animals being compared, features being incorporated, characteristics being shown. The answer often requires you to list and briefly describe.

Why this exists. Tests whether you can pick out specific named entities or features and the relationships described between them in the text.

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The [items/features] are: [item 1] (which [briefly describes the link to the concept]); [item 2] (which [briefly describes the link]).

What the marker is looking for

- Identify the items precisely. Use the text's labels.
- If the question asks “in which ways are they similar”, include the link (do not just name the items).
- Match the count to the mark allocation.

Step 1. Identify the comparison or set of features the question refers to.

Step 2. Locate the named entities in the text.

Step 3. If the question asks for ways or similarities, find them in the text.

Step 4. Write the answer: name each item, then briefly describe the link if required.

Worked Example — IDENTIFICATION — Section C

Question (2020): In Paragraph 1, jackass penguins are compared to two animals. Which animals are they, and in which ways are jackass penguins similar to each of them?

Model answer.

Animal 1: *Donkeys* — jackass penguins are similar to donkeys in that they make a loud, braying call.

Animal 2: *Sheep* — jackass penguins are similar to sheep in that they huddle closely together in groups.

Why this works. Both named animals are identified. For each, the way in which the penguins are similar is stated. The link is explicit, not just implied.

A weaker attempt

“Donkeys and sheep.”

What went wrong. The animals are identified, but the “in which ways” part of the question is not addressed. The student loses marks for an incomplete answer.

Pitfalls. Do not omit the link if the question asks for it. Do not invent comparisons not stated in the text.

JUSTIFICATION — explain how the writer or actor could justify a claim

Concept. A claim is stated (often involving a choice, decision, or action) and you are asked how the actor (e.g. filmmakers, scientists) could justify it. You must find evidence in the named paragraph and explain how that evidence supports the claim.

Why this exists. This tests whether you can build an argument from the text: locate the evidence and articulate why it would justify the stated position.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Subject] could justify this on the grounds that “[*anchor*]”, which [explain how the evidence supports the claim], demonstrating [link: how it justifies the position].

What the marker is looking for

- Evidence must come from the named paragraph.
- Lifting is acceptable for the evidence; paraphrasing or explanation is required to demonstrate understanding.
- The explanation must show why the evidence *justifies* the claim — not merely repeat it.

Step 1. Identify the claim that needs to be justified.

Step 2. Locate evidence in the named paragraph that supports the claim.

Step 3. Quote or paraphrase the evidence.

Step 4. Write a short explanation that shows how the evidence justifies the claim.

Worked Example — JUSTIFICATION — Section C

Question (1184 Specimen Q15): The writer says that the dinosaurs featured in the film, Jurassic Park, “are far from scientifically accurate”. With reference to Paragraph 1, how could the filmmakers justify this?

Model answer. The filmmakers could justify this on the grounds that “*the films were made for entertainment, not for scientific documentation*”. This shows that the priority was to create an engaging cinematic experience for audiences, which justifies taking creative liberties with biological detail.

Why this works. The evidence is quoted from the named paragraph. The explanation shows how the evidence justifies the claim (entertainment goal ⇒ scientific accuracy not required).

A weaker attempt

“Because it’s just a film.”

What went wrong. No evidence cited. No explanation given. The student has supplied a casual opinion, not a justification drawn from the text. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not give an opinion without evidence. Do not lift evidence without explaining it.

WHY / GIVE REASON — explain the writer’s reason for a choice

Concept. The question asks why the writer made a particular choice: referred to certain words, depicted dinosaurs in a certain way, used a specific phrase. You must identify the reason and demonstrate understanding of why this is the writer’s reason.

Why this exists. This tests deeper comprehension: not just what the text says, but why the writer chose to put it that way.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The writer refers to/depicts [thing] because [reason in your own words], as suggested by “[*anchor*]” [explain link].

What the marker is looking for

- The reason must be supportable from the text.
- Demonstrate understanding by using your own words (do not just lift).
- Reference the relevant text briefly if helpful.

Step 1. Identify the writer’s choice that the question asks about.

Step 2. Locate the relevant evidence in the text.

Step 3. Identify the underlying reason.

Step 4. Write the answer: state the reason in own words, supported by the text.

Worked Example — WHY / GIVE REASON — Section C

Question (1184 Specimen Q17): Paragraph 3 says that the dinosaurs were depicted in the films with an “absence of feathers”. What was the reason for this decision?

Model answer. The filmmakers chose to depict the dinosaurs without feathers because feathered dinosaurs would have appeared less frightening and less impressive on screen, undermining the films’ aim of creating menacing, awe-inspiring creatures.

Why this works. The reason is stated clearly. It is grounded in the text (filmmakers’ priority of menace and spectacle) and expressed in own words.

A weaker attempt

“Because feathers look strange.”

What went wrong. The reason given is not supported by the text. It is a vague personal opinion. The marker cannot link it to the passage.

Pitfalls. Do not invent a reason not supported by the text. Do not merely lift without explanation. Distinguish between “why” (the reason) and “how” (the method).

EXPLANATION — explain in own words what a phrase or idea means

Concept. The question quotes a phrase or sentence from the text and asks you to explain what it means or what the writer means by it. You must demonstrate understanding by rephrasing in your own words.

Why this exists. This tests genuine comprehension. Lifting back the original phrase shows nothing; rephrasing it shows that you understand it.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

By “[*anchor*]”, the writer means that [explain in your own words], suggesting that [link: the broader implication].

What the marker is looking for

- Quote the phrase being explained.
- Use your own words to rephrase. Do not lift content words.
- Convey the full meaning, including any implication or shade of meaning.

Step 1. Identify the phrase being explained.

Step 2. Read it in context to grasp the meaning.

Step 3. Rephrase it using different vocabulary.

Step 4. Add the implication if relevant.

Worked Example — EXPLANATION — Section C

Question (Specimen): The writer states that the problem of marine litter is so pervasive it is “from pole to pole”. Explain why the writer chooses to describe the problem with this underlined phrase.

Model answer. By “*from pole to pole*”, the writer means that marine litter is found at the extreme northern and southern ends of the planet — the Arctic and Antarctic — not just in populated regions, suggesting that the contamination is truly global and that no part of the ocean has escaped human pollution.

Why this works. The phrase is quoted. Its meaning is unpacked in own words. The implication (global scale, no escape) is added to demonstrate full comprehension.

A weaker attempt

“It means from one pole to the other.”

What went wrong. A literal restatement that adds no comprehension. The student has not explained what the phrase *means* in the context of marine litter (global pervasiveness).

Pitfalls. Do not lift back the phrase. Do not give a definition without context. Do not miss the implication.

CARTOON HEAD — supply evidence to support a student’s stated view

Concept. The question shows a picture or speech-bubble cartoon of two students with opposing views about the text. You are asked to find evidence from named paragraphs to support each student’s view (or sometimes only one student’s view).

Why this exists. This tests whether you can locate and link specific evidence to specific positions. The cartoon-head format makes the opposing positions vivid; the work is the same as Justification but split between two viewpoints.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

To support [Student A]’s view: “[*anchor 1*]” — this shows that [explain]. *Or for multiple-point variants, give two distinct anchors and explanations.*

To support [Student B]’s view: “[*anchor 2*]” — this shows that [explain].

What the marker is looking for

- Evidence must come from the named paragraph.
- Direct lifting is permitted for the evidence; explanation should use own words.
- Each piece of evidence must clearly support that student’s position — not the opposing one.

Step 1. Identify each student’s stated view.

Step 2. For each, locate evidence in the named paragraph that supports the view.

Step 3. Quote or paraphrase the evidence.

Step 4. Explain how the evidence backs the view (in own words).

Worked Example — CARTOON HEAD — Section C

Question (1184 Specimen Q19a): Give two pieces of evidence from Paragraph 6 to support Tian Yun’s view: “I don’t think it matters that the films aren’t factually accurate.”

Model answer.

Evidence (i): “*The films generated huge interest in dinosaurs among children worldwide.*” This shows that the inaccuracies did not prevent the films from inspiring genuine curiosity about palaeontology — the educational outcome justifies the creative liberties.

Evidence (ii): “*Museums reported a surge in visits after each film’s release.*” This shows that the films’ impact in driving real-world engagement with science outweighs the factual inaccuracies they contain.

Why this works. Two distinct pieces of evidence from the named paragraph. Each is explained in a way that supports the specific view (inaccuracies don’t matter). Inverted commas frame the evidence.

A weaker attempt

“She is right because films are fun.”

What went wrong. No evidence cited from the named paragraph. The reason given (films are fun) is a personal opinion, not textual evidence. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not give evidence for the wrong student’s view. Do not skip the explanation. Do not give evidence from outside the named paragraph.

Section C — Inference Question Types**ATTITUDE — identify the writer’s attitude towards something**

Concept. The question asks what the writer’s attitude towards something or someone is. The answer is an attitude word (one word or short phrase) describing how the writer feels about or judges the subject.

Why this exists. Attitude is the writer’s evaluative stance — how they regard the subject. It is different from *tone* (which is how the writer’s words sound) and from *feeling/emotion* (which is what the writer feels). Cambridge tests attitude regularly in Section C because non-narrative texts often carry a clear evaluative position.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE**► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE**

[Attitude word or short phrase].

Examples of attitude words: dismissive, scornful, admiring, critical, sceptical, sympathetic, condescending, contemptuous, approving, ambivalent, indignant, reverent.

What the marker is looking for

- Build a vocabulary bank for attitude words. Distinguish them from feelings (sad, happy, afraid) and from tones (sarcastic, urgent).
- For 1-mark questions: one precise attitude word is usually enough.
- The attitude must be defensible from the surrounding text.

Step 1. Identify the subject of the writer’s attitude (e.g. “car owners”).

Step 2. Read the surrounding sentences. Note evaluative cues: word choice, irony, intensifiers, dismissive phrasing.

Step 3. Choose an attitude word that fits the cues.

Step 4. Check: is this an attitude (evaluative stance) and not a feeling or tone?

Worked Example — ATTITUDE — Section C

Question (2017): In the first sentence, the writer uses the phrase “the world’s car-obsessed inhabitants”. What is the writer’s attitude towards the car owners of today?

Model answer. *Critical* (or *disapproving* / *condescending*).

Why this works. The word “obsessed” carries a clearly negative evaluation: it implies the writer regards modern car ownership as excessive and irrational. “Critical” captures this evaluative stance cleanly.

A weaker attempt

“Angry.”

What went wrong. “Angry” is a feeling, not an attitude. The writer is not described as enraged. They are evaluating others’ behaviour negatively, which is an attitude (critical, disapproving), not an emotional state.

Pitfalls. Do not confuse with tone or feeling. Do not use vague descriptors. Build the vocabulary bank.

INVERTED COMMAS — explain why the writer puts scare quotes on a word

Concept. The text places certain words or phrases in inverted commas (e.g. “planted”, “free”). The question asks why. You must explain the writer’s purpose in marking the word this way: usually to signal that the writer does not endorse the word’s surface meaning, or to imply irony, sarcasm, or the opposite of what is being claimed.

Why this exists. Writers use scare quotes to signal distance from a word. The reader who notices the inverted commas can detect this rhetorical move. The question tests this awareness.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The writer puts “[*anchor*]” in inverted commas to signal that [explain: the writer does not accept the literal meaning / is being ironic / implies the opposite], suggesting that [link: the true situation as the writer sees it].

What the marker is looking for

- Acknowledge the inverted commas as a rhetorical marker.
- Explain what the writer is signalling: irony, sarcasm, scepticism, the opposite of the apparent meaning.
- Reference the text to support your reading.

Step 1. Identify the word(s) in inverted commas.

Step 2. Ask: would the writer use this word straightforwardly, or are they marking it as suspect?

Step 3. Identify what the writer’s actual view appears to be (in the surrounding text).

Step 4. Write the answer: the inverted commas signal scepticism/irony, and the writer’s real view is X.

Worked Example — INVERTED COMMAS — Section C

Question (2018): Why do you think the writer puts inverted commas in the text round the word “planted”?

Model answer. The writer puts “*planted*” in inverted commas to signal that the word is being used ironically: although officials claim the trees were properly planted, the writer suggests the planting was superficial and inadequate, with no genuine care for whether the trees would survive.

Why this works. The inverted commas are identified as a rhetorical marker. The signalled meaning (irony, scepticism) is explained. The writer’s actual view (superficial, inadequate) is given.

A weaker attempt

“Because it is a quote.”

What went wrong. The student has confused inverted commas around a quoted word with inverted commas as a rhetorical device. There is no source being quoted; the writer is signalling distance from the word itself. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not say the inverted commas mean the word is “a quotation”. Recognise the rhetorical move (irony, scepticism, sarcasm). Always tie back to the writer’s view.

VOCABULARY — define a word and link it to the text

Concept. The question asks why the writer refers to something using a specific word (e.g. “insidious”, “pervasive”). You must define the word *and* explain why the writer chose it for this context. The choice signals something specific about the writer’s view of the subject.

Why this exists. This is the syllabus’s “vocabulary in context” skill. The marker wants to see that you understand the word’s meaning and can explain why the writer chose this particular word.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

The word “[*anchor*]” means [definition in your own words]. The writer chooses this word because [explain how the word’s meaning applies to this subject], suggesting [link: what the writer is conveying about the subject].

What the marker is looking for

- Define the word precisely. Do not use a near-synonym; give the actual meaning.
- Explain why this word fits the subject in the text.
- Identify what the writer conveys by using this word rather than a neutral alternative.

Step 1. Identify the word the question targets.

Step 2. Define it.

Step 3. Read the sentence in context. Why is this word the right one?

Step 4. Identify the implication: what does the word’s connotation tell us about the writer’s view of the subject?

Step 5. Write the answer: definition + connection to the subject + implication.

Worked Example — VOCABULARY — Section C

Question (2017): Why does the writer refer to pollution as an “insidious” side effect?

Model answer. The word “*insidious*” means harmful in a gradual, often hidden way. The writer chooses this word because pollution from cars does not cause obvious immediate damage; instead, it accumulates slowly in the air and the body, doing harm before its effects become noticeable. This suggests that pollution is more dangerous than people realise precisely because it operates invisibly.

Why this works. The word is defined. The connection to the subject (gradual, hidden harm) is made explicit. The implication (more dangerous than realised) is stated.

A weaker attempt

“Because pollution is bad.”

What went wrong. The student has not defined “insidious”. They have not explained what is specifically captured by this word as opposed to “bad” or “harmful”. The vocabulary skill is not demonstrated. No marks.

Pitfalls. Do not skip the definition. Do not give a near-synonym in place of a definition. Always link the word's meaning to why it fits the subject.

TONE OF VOICE — identify the tone of the writer’s comment

Note. This question type appears in Section B in identical form (for character speech). In Section C, the tone is usually the writer’s own (rather than a character’s). The technique is the same: read the cues, choose a precise tone word.

Concept. The question asks for the writer’s tone when making a particular comment. The answer is a tone word.

Why this exists. The writer’s tone signals their stance and shapes how the reader receives the comment. Identifying it is a key inferential skill.

CORE MOVE INSTANCE

► SENTENCE STRUCTURE TO MEMORISE

[Tone word or short phrase].

For 2-mark variants: The tone is [tone word]. This is shown by “[*anchor*]”, which suggests that the writer [explain manner].

What the marker is looking for

- Build a vocabulary bank: *ironic, sarcastic, mocking, wry, sombre, indignant, urgent, dismissive, conspiratorial, sceptical, admiring, regretful, defiant*.
- Tone is the manner of the writer’s voice, not their feeling.
- For 1-mark questions, a single precise tone word is usually enough.

Step 1. Read the quoted comment in context.

Step 2. Note cues: word choice, punctuation, irony, the topic.

Step 3. Choose a tone word that captures the cues.

Step 4. For higher-mark variants, add evidence and explanation.

Worked Example — TONE OF VOICE — Section C

Question (1184 Specimen Q18b): In Paragraph 6, the dinosaur Indominus rex is described as “the most accurate of them all” — but the writer says it cannot be “interrogated by scientists”. What is the writer’s tone when he makes this comment?

Model answer. *Ironic* (or *wry*).

Why this works. The writer says Indominus rex is the “most accurate” — but the dinosaur is fictional and cannot be checked against reality. The accuracy claim is therefore a joke at the expense of scientific verification. “Ironic” captures this self-aware double meaning.

A weaker attempt

“Serious.”

What went wrong. The student has missed the irony. The writer is not making this comment seriously; they are pointing out the absurdity of calling a fictional creature “accurate”. “Serious” misses the entire joke.

Pitfalls. Watch for irony cues: claims that are technically true but absurd, comments that undercut themselves. Do not confuse tone with what is being literally said.

Chapter 5. Teacher Reference — 1184 Alignment

Mapping question types to the 1184 syllabus skills

The SEAB 1184 syllabus specifies three skill areas for Sections B and C: **comprehension**, **vocabulary in context**, and **language for effect**. The fourteen Section B and thirteen Section C question types in this document are practitioner taxonomies derived from past Cambridge papers and the 1184 Specimen Paper. The table below maps each question type to its primary syllabus skill area.

Question Type	Section	Primary Syllabus Skill
LITERAL	B, C	Comprehension
EVIDENCE	B	Comprehension
QUOTATION	B, C	Comprehension
OWN WORDS	B, C	Vocabulary in context
EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE	B	Comprehension (advanced)
CONTRAST	B	Comprehension
FLOW CHART	B	Comprehension (paragraph-level)
INFERENTIAL	B	Comprehension (inferential)
CHARACTER IMPRESSION	B	Comprehension (inferential)
TONE OF VOICE	B, C	Comprehension (inferential)
LITERARY DEVICE	B	Language for effect
LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT	B	Language for effect
TECHNICAL	B	Language for effect
GIVE EXAMPLE	C	Comprehension
IDENTIFICATION	C	Comprehension
JUSTIFICATION	C	Comprehension (advanced)
WHY / GIVE REASON	C	Comprehension (inferential)
EXPLANATION	C	Comprehension + Vocabulary
CARTOON HEAD	C	Comprehension (synthesis)
ATTITUDE	C	Comprehension (inferential)
INVERTED COMMAS	C	Language for effect
VOCABULARY	C	Vocabulary in context

Mark allocation patterns observed in past 1184 papers

- **Section B** total: 20 marks across approximately 9–10 questions.
- **Section C** total: 25 marks across approximately 5–7 comprehension questions plus the 15-mark summary.
- Single-mark questions are usually *Locate* types (LITERAL, EVIDENCE, QUOTATION) or short Inference questions (TONE, ATTITUDE).
- Two-mark questions usually pair *Locate* plus brief explanation, or two parallel points.
- Three-mark questions are usually EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE or LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT with three details.
- Four-mark questions are usually the FLOW CHART (one mark per correct match).

Question types not covered in this document

- **Section A visual text questions** (5 marks total) — separate A-Worthy document.
- **Summary question** (Section C Q20, 15 marks) — separate A-Worthy document.
- **ODDWORD-style “unusual and effective” questions** from pre-1184 papers — not in 1184 Specimen; deprecated for this taxonomy.

- **MINDSET-style reaction/state-of-mind questions** from pre-1184 papers — not in 1184 Specimen; treated as a sub-variant of INFERENTIAL where it appears.

Teaching sequence suggestions

For a structured course, the recommended teaching order is:

1. **Foundation (start here).** LITERAL, EVIDENCE, QUOTATION, OWN WORDS — accessible marks, build confidence.
2. **The Core Move.** Introduce Anchor + Explain + Link via INFERENTIAL. Drill until automatic.
3. **Apply Core Move.** Spread to CHARACTER IMPRESSION, TONE, ATTITUDE, EXPLANATION, JUSTIFICATION.
4. **Language analysis.** LITERARY DEVICE, LANGUAGE FOR EFFECT, TECHNICAL, VOCABULARY, INVERTED COMMAS.
5. **Advanced.** EXPLAIN-3-EVIDENCE, FLOW CHART, CARTOON HEAD (multi-part, higher cognitive load).

End of document — Paper 2 Blueprint v10
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